Refine: React Admin Without a Fixed UI

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Refine is a headless React framework for CRUD-heavy internal tools, apps built around creating, reading, updating, and deleting records. Instead of shipping one fixed admin interface, it puts a data-provider contract between React screens and REST or GraphQL APIs. Its hooks handle lists, forms, caching, loading states, and invalidation through TanStack Query, while separate providers cover authentication, routing, notifications, live updates, translation, and permissions. The current docs list 10 packaged data providers, three router targets, React

Router, Next.js, and Remix, and five supported UI integrations: shadcn/ui, Ant Design, Material UI, Chakra UI, and Mantine. You can also supply custom components. Version 5.0.12 is a small patch that preserves custom API fields in list results, not a reason by itself to migrate.

Refine makes sense when many screens repeat the same table, filter, form, authentication, and permission patterns. For one or two screens, plain Next.js or Remix leaves fewer framework-specific hooks to unwind later. Refine does not design the workflow or guarantee accessibility. Your component library and application code still determine both. Its access-control provider does nothing until protected routes are wrapped, and browser checks never replace API authorization. React-admin is the closest alternative. It includes default CRUD routes and more than 50 data providers, so teams build less when a standard admin interface fits. Choose Refine when custom product UI matters enough to own, but repetitive data wiring does not.

Sources:

- Refine data provider guide
- Refine UI libraries guide
- Refine access control provider
- Refine 5.0.12 release
- React-admin documentation

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